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FTER JACK WELCH became chairman and managing director of General Electric Co (GE)

in 1981, he shut factories, cut jobs and closed non-performing units in a ruthless consolidation drive.

The drive cost thousands of jobs, but Welch, a legend of American business, had the backing of shareholders to see the

process through. Welch gained the sobriquet Neutron Jack after the neutron bomb, which spreads radiation to kill people, but spares buildings.

GE's consolidation marked the start of the decline of American conglomerates, or sprawling multi-industry, multinational business groups with independent subsidiaries; it's a process that has continued for a quarter century

with one set of conglomerates replacing another.

In India, too, many family-owned conglomerates like the Mafatlals, the Thapar Group, Videocon Industries, owned by the Dhoots, and Walchandnagar, controlled by the Doshis, have faded in recent decades. True, other large multi-generational Indian groups like the Tatas, Aditya Birla Group, Godrej and Mahindra and